the caste census plank could be rich fertiliser for the field the Congress was ploughing, becoming a live factor in a novel way it had not anticipated. A vague or tangible dread of losing reservations could actually be getting large parts of the voting public to circle their wagons against that threat.

BJP'S DAMAGE CONTROL

Suddenly, the BJP star team went into urgent reparation mode. Everyone from Modi to Union home minister Amit Shah hotly denied that there was ever any question of amending the Constitution or ending reservations. In 2015, a call for a "social review" of reservations by RSS sarsanghchalak Mohan Bhagwat, which he has often tried to walk back on since, had famously turned that year's Bihar assembly election. On April 28, Bhagwat, too, spoke out: "Reservation should remain in place as long as discriminations are not eliminated." The BJP also realised that all this went beyond the playfield of 'social engineering' where it had by now built specialised skills. There, pure tactical play could offer access to chunks from the caste landscape—say, a couple of Bharat Ratnas handed out as blandishment, or the diligent wooing of a spectrum of poor backward castes through alliances and segmented quotas. Unfolding here was a chapter of a greater epic.

If the BJP faces an introspective moment presently, it's because it is truly in a dilemma over the caste census and reservations. One immediate symptom of that inner conflict is the disquiet owing to reports of anger among Rajputs in Gujarat, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh—part of its oldest vote layers. The BJP's evolution since the 1990s had entailed expanding that base by stacking great numbers of OBCs atop that. The process acquired unprecedented momentum in the Modi years. Analyses by the Centre for the Study of Developing Societies (CSDS) saw the BJP's vote share among OBCs double from 22 per cent in 2009—via 34 per cent in 2014—to 44 per cent in 2019. Prof. K. Ravikant of Lucknow University says the BJP accomplished this "not through Hindutva but representation", assiduously winning over hitherto ignored Extremely Backward Classes (EBCs) by offering them space, from the local level to the Union cabinet. Those who see 'Mandal' and 'Mandir' as polar opposites miss how transformative and creative Mandal has been for saffron: it's precisely the addition of caste to its diet that allowed the BJP to escape its old forward caste-dominated trap of a 25-27 per cent vote share. That core vote, it reck-



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

THE MUSLIM QUOTA

- There is no constitutional provision for reservations on the basis of religion, and equality laws debar it by implication. But **Article 16(4)** allows quotas in jobs "in favour of any backward class of citizens...not adequately represented"
- About a dozen states have either specific sub-quotas for Muslim groups on a backwardness basis or progressively include groups in the OBC list without any fixed share for them
- Specific sub-quotas often face legal challenge for being on a "religious basis". The May 22 Calcutta HC verdict struck down inclusion in OBC lists for being done without proper survey
- Muslim quotas began in princely Mysore in 1874, but in free India, **Kerala** was first off the blocks, formalising a colonial-era quota for Muslims during state formation in 1956: now 12% in government jobs and 8% in education. All Muslims were classified as OBCs in 1958
- In **Karnataka**, despite the previous BJP regime's attempt to scrap it, the Muslim quota stands at 4% since the 1990s. In **Tamil Nadu**, it's 3.5%, introduced in 2007. Elite caste Muslims not covered
- In **Andhra Pradesh** and **Telangana**, similar sub-quotas are stuck in legal tangles for years. In **Haryana**, too, Muslim Jats were among the six groups allocated a 10% quota under